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PRACTICAL GUIDE · 2026 EDITION

9 free tools that replace paid software.

Open-source alternatives to Higgsfield, ElevenLabs, Semrush, Notion, Wispr Flow, Asana, Calendly, Intercom and Loom: what each one does, who it's for, and how to get it running.

```
$ paid apps → $0 / month
```


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01 · WHY OPEN SOURCE

Same jobs. No subscription.

Open-source software publishes its code openly. You can use it free, run it on your own computer or server, and your data stays with you.

PAID APP	FREE ALTERNATIVE	WHAT IT DOES
Higgsfield	Open Higgsfield	AI image + video studio
ElevenLabs	VoiceStudio	Voice cloning & text-to-speech
Semrush	OpenSEO	Rank tracking, backlinks, site audits
Notion	AppFlowy	Notes, docs, wikis & task boards
Wispr Flow	OpenWhispr	Voice dictation anywhere
Asana	OpenProject	Projects, Gantt charts, time tracking
Calendly	Cal.diy	Scheduling & booking pages
Intercom	Chatwoot	Live chat + email in one inbox
Loom	Cap	Screen recording & sharing

What you gain

- No monthly fees
- Your data on your own machine
- No limits set by a pricing plan

What it costs instead

- A little setup time
- You handle updates and backups
- Some features may differ from the paid app

02 · WHAT YOU NEED

Three ways to run them.

A

Desktop app: easiest

Download the installer from the repo's **Releases** page (or the project website) and install it like any app. AppFlowy OpenWhispr Cap

B

Docker: for servers and team tools

Install Docker Desktop, then run the project with the Docker Compose file from its README. OpenProject Chatwoot Cal.diy OpenSEO

C

Run locally from source: for AI tools

Clone the repo and follow its setup steps, usually installing Python or Node.js dependencies. Open Higgsfield VoiceStudio

03 · HOW TO INSTALL ANY REPO

The universal routine

```
# 1. Get the code
$ git clone https://github.com/OWNER/REPO.git
$ cd REPO
# 2. Server apps: start them with Docker (if the README has a compose file)
$ docker compose up -d
# 3. Then open the address the README gives, e.g. http://localhost:3000
```

Always follow the README. Every project has its own setup steps, settings and environment variables. The commands above are the common pattern, not exact instructions for every repo.

Before you install

- **Git** to clone repos
- **Docker Desktop** for server apps
- Enough disk space and RAM
- A GPU helps for AI voice and video

Read these first

- **README**: setup steps
- **Releases**: ready-made installers
- **License**: what you can do with it
- **Issues**: known problems

04 · AI & CREATOR TOOLS

Create without credits.

Open Higgsfield

#01

replaces ~~Higgsfield~~ · AI image + video studio

One prompt bar for image and video generation models, with each model's settings and a gallery of every finished run.

Best for	Creators who generate a lot of AI images and video
How it runs	Runs locally; you bring API keys for the models you use
Repo	`github.com/wide-trace/open-higgsfield`

VoiceStudio

#02

replaces ~~ElevenLabs~~ · Voice cloning & text-to-speech

Clone a voice from a short sample and generate speech, running on your own machine instead of a paid cloud service.

Best for	Voice-overs and dubbing without a monthly plan
How it runs	Runs locally; a GPU makes it much faster
Repo	`github.com/debpalash/VoiceStudio`

Cap

#09

replaces ~~Loom~~ · Screen recording & sharing

Record your screen and camera, then share a link or export the video.

Best for	Tutorials, async updates, bug reports
How it runs	Desktop app download (macOS / Windows)
Repo	`github.com/CapSoftware/Cap`

05 · WORK & PRODUCTIVITY

Plan, write and get work done.

AppFlowy

#04

replaces ~~Notion~~ · Notes, docs, wikis & task boards

A Notion-style workspace (pages, databases, kanban boards) where your data stays under your control.

Best for	Personal notes, team wikis, project boards
How it runs	Desktop & mobile apps; optional self-hosted sync server
Repo	`github.com/AppFlowy-IO/AppFlowy`

OpenWhispr

#05

replaces ~~Wispr Flow~~ · Voice dictation anywhere

Speak and have it typed into any app, using local Whisper speech models so it can even work offline.

Best for	Fast writing, accessibility, multilingual typing
How it runs	Desktop app; local models download on first use
Repo	`github.com/OpenWhispr/openwhispr`

OpenProject

#06

replaces ~~Asana~~ · Projects, Gantt charts, time tracking

Full project management: tasks, timelines, Gantt charts, boards and time tracking for teams.

Best for	Teams that need planning and reporting
How it runs	Self-host (Docker or packages) or a hosted plan
Repo	`github.com/opf/openproject`

06 · BUSINESS TOOLS

Grow and support customers.

OS

OpenSEO

#03

replaces ~~Semrush~~ · Rank tracking, backlinks, site audits

Track where your pages rank, see who links to you, and audit your site for SEO problems.

Best for	Bloggers, small businesses, agencies
How it runs	Self-host; some data sources may need their own API keys
Repo	`github.com/every-app/open-seo`

CD

Cal.diy

#07

replaces ~~Calendly~~ · Scheduling & booking pages

Share a booking link, let people pick a time, and sync bookings with Google and Outlook calendars.

Best for	Consultants, creators, sales calls
How it runs	Self-host; connect your calendar accounts
Repo	`github.com/calcom/cal.diy`

CW

Chatwoot

#08

replaces ~~Intercom~~ · Live chat + email in one inbox

Website live chat, email and social messages in one shared inbox for your support team.

Best for	Businesses handling customer support
How it runs	Self-host with Docker, or a hosted plan
Repo	`github.com/chatwoot/chatwoot`

07 · WHICH ONE FIRST?

Pick by what you do.

IF YOU ARE A...	START WITH
Content creator	Cap, Open Higgsfield, VoiceStudio
Writer or student	AppFlowy, OpenWhispr
Freelancer or consultant	Cal.diy, AppFlowy, Cap
Small business	Chatwoot, OpenSEO, Cal.diy
Team lead	OpenProject, AppFlowy, Chatwoot

08 · Stay safe

Check before you run

Look for recent commits, an active Issues tab and a clear license. Download only from the official repo or website.

Protect your keys

Keep API keys in the project's settings or `.env` file. Never paste them into public code or screenshots.

Back up your data

Self-hosted means you own the backups. Export or back up your data folders regularly.

Keep it updated

Update from the Releases page, or pull the latest version and restart, to get security fixes.

09 · Cheat sheet

```
$ git clone https://github.com/OWNER/REPO.git # get the code
$ docker compose up -d                # start a server app
$ docker compose pull && docker compose up -d # update it
$ docker compose down                 # stop it
```

Found this useful?
More AI tools explained simply, in Telugu and English.

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